

CHAPTER 6

SETTING PRIORITIES

By now you probably have set specific goals for your work, and you have some ideas for accomplishing them. But how do you decide what to do first? A measure of your effectiveness is how skillfully you are able to establish your priorities in order to progress toward your goals. With many responsibilities and activities demanding your attention, you need a way to determine which goals receive the investment of your time and your energy. Only with a practical system for setting priorities will you be able to concentrate on the tasks for reaching your goals. Take a few moments to respond to the priority-setting checklist.

PRIORITY-SETTING CHECKLIST

	Yes	No
1. I set priorities regularly.	_____	_____
2. I establish priorities on a long-term basis as well as on a short-term basis.	_____	_____
3. I use criteria to establish my priorities.	_____	_____
4. I regularly work on the high-priority issues.	_____	_____
5. I recognize the value of applying my time and energy to the high-priority issues.	_____	_____
6. I communicate my priorities to others who are affected by my actions.	_____	_____

A health-care executive faced with many interruptions in the day established a quiet time for himself when he would address priorities. He learned to post a DO NOT DISTURB note on his office door from 7:00 to 9:00 A.M. He then would concentrate on his high-priority tasks, one at a time. The result has been an increasing rate of productivity.

SETTING YOUR PRIORITIES

How do you decide what to do each day? And how do you decide which activities get your attention first? Often we set our priorities in a way that feels comfortable to us rather than in a way that addresses our goals most effectively. Read these statements and check those that apply to you:

I set my priorities by:

My job description—“I first do what is related to my job.”

- ☐ **The squeaky wheel**—“Whoever or whatever squeaks the loudest gets my attention.”
- ☐ **What my supervisor says to do.**
- ☐ **Doing the easy ones first**—getting the minor tasks out of the way.
- ☐ **Doing the most difficult ones first.**
- ☐ **Last in, first out**—the latest issue gets the top priority.
- ☐ **First in, first out**—issues are dealt with in the order in which they come.
- ☐ **What is most interesting at the moment.**

None of these approaches is optimally effective because none uses a rational, consistent criterion for determining what needs to be done. And without rational criteria to set priorities, you may not work on your most important goals first.

DOING FIRST THINGS FIRST

Problem: You return to your office and find ten telephone messages, and you have only thirty minutes in which to return the calls. **Solution:** Rank the calls in order of importance so you make the high-impact calls first.

A rational system evaluates facts, is easy to use, can incorporate flexible criteria, and is accurate. Remember the 80-20 rule: Of all the things you could be doing to reach your goals, it is likely that about 20 percent of your current effort yields 80 percent of your results. So, there is a good reason to work smarter.

SETTING CRITERIA

An effective method for establishing priorities is to use a table (see [Figure 6-1](#)). The first column identifies your concerns, which may include your goals, current projects, and activities. Subsequent columns identify criteria to evaluate your concerns.

Criteria often used to rank concerns are *importance* and *urgency*. With regard to importance, consider the impact of each concern on your goals. Is it an activity of high impact? What impact is likely in terms of cost? Use of resources? What kind of an effect will this activity have on your reaching your goals? As you evaluate your activities using each criterion, assign a number to indicate the level of importance (high = 3, medium = 2, low = 1) and enter this number in the appropriate space of the table.

FIGURE 6-1. TABLE FOR EVALUATING CONCERNS BY RATING THE CRITERIA.

Concerns	Criteria	
	Importance	Urgency
1.		
2.		
3.		
4.		
5.		

Follow the same guidelines for evaluating the urgency of a concern. What are its deadlines? Is it a project or goal that requires immediate attention, can it wait for a while, or can it be put aside indefinitely? As you did with the level of importance, assign a number value to indicate the level of urgency for each concern.

There are several thoughts to keep in mind as you use this table. First, people often equate urgency with importance. But the distinction is that importance has to do with *impact* and urgency has to do with *time*. Also, remember that each criterion is evaluated on its own merit. As you consider your activities and goals, evaluate their importance and then their urgency relative to each other, considering one concern at a time. For ease, focus, and consistency, limit your criteria to four.

The table in [Figure 6-2](#) illustrates the method of using criteria to evaluate a list of goals, activities, and/or projects.

Rarely are there right and wrong answers, but this method of setting priorities is a defensible systematic strategy for establishing priorities. Once you identify the priority of your activities, you are poised to apply your time and energy to your goals more effectively. Your productivity will skyrocket!

Use this method when establishing both individual and group priorities. Even though you are likely to find that your priorities differ from those of others on your team, a systematic review of priorities provides a base of rational thought for supporting your position. When using this method, changes in opinion tend to be driven by facts rather than emotions. Generally you will find reaching agreement quicker and easier through a system that is rationally defensible.

To practice setting priorities, consider the issues, activities, and/or projects that you must deal with in the next week. Using the table shown in [Figure 6-3](#) on page 62, list your issues and concerns, then rank each using the criterion of importance, then of urgency. Total the score and rank your results.

When establishing your criteria, you may decide to use different ones from importance or urgency. The criteria may change depending on what is most relevant to your goals. A key factor in setting priorities successfully is that you are consistent in choosing and applying the criteria.

FIGURE 6-2. SAMPLE FILLED-OUT TABLE SHOWING THE CRITERIA RATING METHOD.

Activities	Criteria		Total	Ranking
	Importance	Urgency		
1. You have twenty-four hours to submit a grant proposal.	L = 1	H = 3	4	4
2. There has been an oil spill.	H = 3	H = 3	6	1
3. There is a formal complaint against one of your employees regarding sexual harassment.	M = 2	L = 1	3	7
4. A secretary needs to be hired within thirty days.	M = 2	H = 3	5	3
5. A time-and-motion study of the productivity in your department must be completed.	L = 1	L = 1	2	8
6. Four of your employees must attend training on sexual harassment two weeks from now.	M = 2	M = 2	4	5
7. Your CEO will be visiting your plant in one week to tour. His current priorities include adherence to environmental regulations.	H = 3	H = 3	6	2
8. Six performance appraisals must be completed in the next two months.	M = 2	M = 2	4	6

A group of twenty department heads from a utility company identified twenty-five barriers that were keeping them from working together effectively. They needed to build consensus regarding their five most important issues. The criteria to prioritize each issue was the degree to which each issue: (1) met organizational goals, (2) enabled the productivity of each department head, and (3) enhanced communication of the group. Within three hours the group arrived at a common priority ranking for those issues and initiated planning to address the top concerns.

FIGURE 6-3. TABLE FOR RANKING ISSUES ACCORDING TO CRITERIA RATING.

Issues	Criteria		Total	Ranking
	Importance	Urgency		
1.				
2.				
3.				
4.				
5.				

YOUR PRIORITIES—DON'T KEEP THEM A SECRET!

A common complaint among employees is that the supervisors do not communicate their priorities. Instead, they assign work and establish goals with little or no apparent rationale. If you take the time to communicate your priorities in relationship to your goals, employees will better understand their role in helping you reach those goals. And your bonus is an improvement in morale!